
A FREE GUIDE FROM COACH WENDY MADER

How World-Class Athletes Stay on Top — Without Overtraining

The insider habits I share with my own athletes: train smarter, recover better, and race your best without burning out.

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The athletes who last aren't the ones who train the most.

I learned this the hard way. After my first Ironman in 1997 I did the obvious thing — I trained more. More volume, more intensity, no rest. Within six months I was in the worst shape of my life, barely able to walk without losing my breath. Then I rebuilt, and in 2008 I won the Overall Amateur title at the Ironman World Championships in Kona.

The difference wasn't doing more. It was doing the right things, consistently, and respecting recovery as part of the work. That's the whole idea behind how I coach: **health first, then fitness, then sport**. Here are the specifics I actually use with my athletes.

"Fatigue isn't a badge of honor. The magic happens when you recover from the work — not while you're piling it on."

1. Running tweaks that make you faster — with zero extra training

Free speed lives in your form, not your mileage.

- **Lift your cadence.** Aim for ~170–180 steps per minute. A quicker, lighter turnover reduces braking and impact instantly.
- **Land under your hips,** not out in front. Overstriding is like tapping the brakes with every step.
- **Lean from the ankles,** not the waist. A slight whole-body lean lets gravity do some of the work.
- **Relax everything above the waist.** Soft hands, low shoulders, loose jaw. Tension is wasted energy.
- **Make easy days genuinely easy.** If you can't hold a conversation, you're too fast — and you're stealing from your hard days.

2. Performance-killing habits the pros avoid before every race

Most bad races are lost in the days before the start, not on the course.

- **Nothing new on race day.** No new shoes, gear, food, or "genius" last-minute ideas. Race what you've practiced.
- **Don't try to cram fitness in the taper.** The hay is in the barn. Extra "panic workouts" only add fatigue.
- **Treat sleep as the real taper.** The two nights before the race matter most — bank rest early in the week, too.
- **Hydrate for days, not hours.** You can't chug your way to hydration on race morning.
- **Don't redline the warm-up.** Warm up to feel smooth, not to prove fitness.
- **Lay everything out the night before.** Decisions made calmly beat decisions made in a pre-dawn scramble.
- **Eat a familiar breakfast,** at a time you've rehearsed in training. Your gut likes routine.

3. Nutrition & training the top athletes actually use

Fuel the work. Under-fueling is the most common mistake I see.

- **Carbs aren't the enemy.** They're the fuel for quality training. Eat enough to support the work you're asking your body to do.
- **Train your gut.** Practice your exact race-day fueling in long sessions so nothing surprises you on the day.
- **Aim for 60–90g of carbs per hour** on long or hard efforts, built up gradually over weeks.
- **Protein drives recovery.** Get a serving within an hour of hard sessions, and spread it across the day.
- **Strength train twice a week.** It's the cheapest injury insurance and durability you can buy.
- **Consistency beats perfection.** Months of "good enough" out-perform a few "perfect" weeks every time.

4. Behind the curtain: racing the big ones

What I think about on the start line of a World Championship.

- **Race your own plan, not the field.** Someone will always go out too hard. Let them.
- **The first half should feel too easy.** Discipline early is what gives you a finish to be proud of.
- **Expect a low patch — and know it passes.** Every long race has one. Keep fueling, keep moving, it lifts.
- **Hold onto your "why."** On the hard stretches, the reason you started is what carries you.
- **The finish is earned in the boring weeks.** Race day is a celebration of the consistency nobody saw.

None of this requires more time or more talent. It requires doing the simple things well, again and again, while staying healthy enough to keep showing up. That's the part a good coach helps you protect.

Want a plan built around your life?

This is the foundation. The real gains come from a plan made for your goals, your schedule, and how your body actually responds. If you'd like that, let's talk — no pressure, just a real conversation.

Book a free 15-minute call · t2coaching.com · t2coachwendy@gmail.com